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Language and Interpretation in 1 Kings 20

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This article offers an interpretation of 1 Kings chapter 20 based on an analysis of the linguistic and structural features of the text.¹ This interpretation is suggested for consideration rather than fully argued. The primary purpose in presenting it is to demonstrate the need for more careful consideration of linguistic usage. It is argued that, when an unusual feature is used, it is necessary to ask not only what it means of itself, but why a more common equivalent was not used. The answer to the latter question must form part of the communication that the passage was intended to make, or must enhance it in some way. It must reflect the "narrator's intention."²

Commentators generally present their assumptions on what is here called "narrator's intention" (e.g., classification of genre, etc.) in terms not of the passage as it stands, but of the sources from which it is believed to have been composed. This attitude is questionable; if the sources themselves are not available, we cannot know the extent to which they have been adapted to fit their new context. If a passage is considered a literary unity – the work of a narrator who intended it to convey some particular information – the wording must be considered the narrator's own (barring errors in transmission). If traces of different sources are visible, it is to be assumed either that they were retained with a purpose, or at least that they did not interfere with the narrator's purpose. It is reasonable to suggest that the compilers of a narrative might overlook contradictions resulting from conflation of sources, but the probability of this must be argued for any particular case to which it is applied.³ A passage should not be treated *a priori* as a collection of independent sources. Unless it can be shown that the sources have not been integrated into a unity, the narrator's intention – the overall purpose of a text which conditions the interpretation of its individual features – must be determined on the basis of the whole, not on the basis of the sources used. Consequently, the question of the extent to which any passage can be considered a literary unit is of first importance.

The Question of Literary Unity In 1 Kings 20

The content of the chapter can be summarized as follows. Verses 1-12 describe an invasion of Israel by Ben Hadad, King of Aram, with a large force. After a negotiation, Ahab, King of Israel, defies Ben Hadad, who orders an attack. In verses 13-14, a prophet brings God's assurance of victory to Ahab, and also instructions on how to obtain it. In verses 15-21 Ahab, acting on these instructions, defeats Ben Hadad soundly. In verse 22, the prophet warns Ahab that Ben Hadad will invade again. Verses 23-27 describe the deliberations of the Aramaeans, their preparations, and a second invasion of Israel. The troops of Israel march out to meet the invading force, and the two armies camp opposite each other. In verse 28 a "man of God" again brings God's assurance of victory to Ahab. In verses 29-34, battle is joined after a delay. Ahab wins a decisive victory. As a result, he gains territorial and commercial advantages, and the two kings make a treaty as equals. Verses 35-43 describe the activities of a prophet who entraps Ahab, by means of a story, into condemning his own actions. The prophet delivers God's judgment, and Ahab returns home.

Many commentators regard the chapter as composed of two sources, one "historical" and one "prophetic." Opinions on the boundaries of these sources differ, but verses 13-14, 22, 28, 35-43, are generally among those designated as "prophetic."⁴ Parts of the repetitive material in verses 16-19 are also often held to be secondary. If this material is not original, the question of unity concerns its integration with the rest of the chapter. Was it the result of design or of accident?

The present positioning of the material named can be explained as designed to raise or sustain interest in the narrative. The introduction of the prophet in verses 13 and 28, just at the point where the battle seems about to begin, delays the narrative. The message he brings raises the question of how, or even if, the promised victory is to be achieved. Both the delay and the question raise suspense. The repetition of forms of יצא (20:16-19), describing the sortie of the troops of Israel, produces the effect of slow motion, which, again, increases the suspense.⁵ The prophet's warning in verse 22 sustains interest at a time when it might well relax, as Ahab's problem appears to be solved. This is also true of the introduction of the prophet in verse 35. Here expectations are increased by the fact that the preceding emissaries have played such an important role. The air of mystery imparted to the actions of this prophet during the slow build-up towards his denunciation of Ahab also heightens suspense.

Similar usage can be seen in other narratives. The repeated presentation of the "arrival" of a messenger in 1 Samuel 4:12-14 with forms of בוא⁶ produces the effect of slow motion, as does the repetition in 1 Kings 20:16-19. The delay of the actual delivery of the message until 1 Sm 4:17 also helps to increase the suspense. The technique of interrupting the narrative is used in 1 Samuel 17. Goliath approaches David in verse 41, but David's reaction is not given until verse 48. The action is delayed by the insertion of material (the speeches of the

combatants) important for the narrator's message. The delay, at this crucial point in the narrative, heightens suspense. The introduction of the prophet in 1 Kgs 20:13, 28, appears to use the same technique for the same purpose.

If the use of "secondary" materials in 1 Kings 20 could represent a technique and purpose common to other narratives, they could have been placed where they now stand in an intentional process of composition.⁷ The chapter is characterized by the regular use of certain syntactic features, showing that its unity is, in fact, a probability. Subject-verb order is used to introduce a main protagonist in a major new section of narrative in vv. 1, 23, 35, and in the imbedded story in v. 39. Where a previously unmentioned character is introduced within such a section, the same order is used, with the subject introduced by *והנה*, in v. 13 and in the imbedded story in v. 39. A pronominal subject preceding its verb is used to mark reversion to a preceding subject after digression on some other topic in v. 19 (*וואלה*), and v. 39 (*והוא*); (cf. the anaphoric *והאנשים* in v. 33). *ויהי* is used to introduce the crucial event in a narrative section in vv. 12, 26, 29, 39, and, in the imbedded story, in v. 40.

Features of this sort are common enough in the Former Prophets, but they are not evenly distributed.⁸ The regularity of usage shown in 1 Kings 20 is unusual, and clearly ought to be considered where the question of unity is raised. Such regularity could well represent the style of a particular narrator, characterizing the chapter as a literary unity. This study proceeds on the assumption that this conclusion is correct.

The "Narrator's Intention"

There is a wide consensus among historians that the events described in this chapter did not take place in Ahab's reign, and some uncertainty as to when they did occur.⁹ If this is correct, it is difficult to believe that the narrator's primary intention was the simple recounting of historical events on a human level. If the "historical" materials were taken from some form of secular history, as is often suggested, the replacement of the original king by Ahab must surely show that they are used here with a different purpose. A study of references to kings shows that a designation of the type "king of Israel," standard for the king in this chapter, is normally used only by or to foreigners. Consequently, if this secular history originated in the northern kingdom, as is often suggested, it has certainly been changed for use in its present situation.

Long has pointed out the narrator's interest in the "preparation," the events leading up to the battles, and the corresponding lack of interest in the events of the battles themselves.¹⁰ The description of the preparation for both battles fosters the expectation of Aramaean victory to the extent that this must be seen as an important purpose for the narrator. Before the first battle, the reference to the 32 kings allied to Ben Hadad (1 Kgs 20:16, repeating 20:1), contrasts with

the number 7,232, given in v. 15 as the total for Ahab's force, suggesting overwhelming Aramaean numerical superiority. Beyond this stress on the disparity in numbers, the arrogance of Ben Hadad's messages (vv. 3, 5-6, 10), and the confidence which he displays in his drinking with his allies (v. 12), and in his assumption that any "men" coming out of the city will easily be captured (v. 18) also gives the impression that his victory is inevitable.¹¹ Ahab himself clearly feels that he has no chance against the invaders, as is shown by his ready submission to Ben Hadad's first demand.

Before the second battle, the expectation of Aramaean victory is raised by the description of their serious preparation for the campaign, including the raising of an army equal to the former one (v. 25). The disparity of numbers is further emphasized by the striking simile in verse 27, as Long notes. The care expended on emphasizing the superiority of Aram in human terms must surely have the purpose of emphasizing the miraculous nature of Israel's victory – victory due to God, and not to the relatively insignificant forces at Ahab's command.

The battle accounts, the core of the chapter, can, then, easily be understood as intended primarily to demonstrate the power of God over human forces, and the miraculous benefits which flow from obedience to him. The terminal section, verses 35-43, is fully consistent with this view. After the second battle, Ahab follows human wisdom. He regains territory, obtains commercial concessions, and establishes a stable relationship with a neighbor he could not expect to dominate in the long term. This is contrary to Ahab's duty to God, so he is punished for his disobedience. It is true that the reader is not told how Ben Hadad should have been treated, but this is not necessary. The ancient audience would know Ahab's duty as clearly as he should have himself.¹²

The punishment for Ahab's disobedience is to be death, in accordance with the prophet's story. It is possible that תשקול in that story (1 Kgs 20:39) should be translated "You will receive [as a reward]," not "You will pay [as a penalty]."¹³ In this case, the silver talent, far more than the value of a prisoner of war (cf. Ex 21:32, Lv 27:1-8), represents the great benefit which Ahab could have obtained if he had done his duty.

Points of Detail

It appears, then, that the chapter is intended to illustrate the omnipotence of God, the benefits of obedience to him, and the penalty of disobedience, by means of a narrative of events in the career of Ahab. If this view is correct, the correct interpretation of other features in the narrative will accord with this intention and support it.¹⁴ Further details of the chapter are considered from this viewpoint. Some features of the battle narratives can be interpreted as strongly supporting this view of the narrator's intention, so these are considered first. After this, some questions in the opening verses of the chapter are considered.

The Battle Scenes

In 1 Kgs 20:14-19, the group that will lead Ahab's sortie is named as **נערי שרי המדינות**, a term not used elsewhere. Where **נער** is used with a noun or pronoun, the general meaning of "servant" is indicated.¹⁵ The identity of the **שרי המדינות** is, then, likely to be crucial to the understanding of the nature of this group. Unfortunately nothing is known of them. **נער** itself has a wide range of use. It can refer to soldiers selected for important combat, as in 2 Sm 2:14.¹⁶ However, the actual tasks performed by **נערים** are not usually such as champions would perform.¹⁷ In 2 Kgs 19:6, the designation of important officials as **נערי מלך אשור** appears to be intended to belittle them.¹⁸ In Jgs 8:20, 1 Sm 17:33, 42, **נער** indicates inexperience. Such use can reasonably be assigned to the "youth" area of the semantic field, but it is also reasonable to question whether Hebrew, with one word, really makes the same lexical categorization as do western European languages with more. **נער** is clearly a term which might be used of any servant or soldier. The nature of those designated in any particular passage can only be determined from the context.

It is quite possible that God's instructions to Ahab in verses 13-14 are intentionally contrary to human wisdom. A besieged force should stay within the walls – Samaria held out against Assyria for three years (2 Kgs 17:5). If the **נערי שרי המדינות** are not experienced troops (and it seems unlikely that the instruction to use them would be given such prominence if they would be the expected choice for desperate work) the sortie as planned would be doubly foolish. As with the reduction of Gideon's army to 300 men (Jgs 7:7, cf. v. 2), or the water on Elijah's sacrifice (1 Kgs 18:34), the task is deliberately made impossible in human terms to demonstrate the power of God. It is interesting that in both these cases, as in the battle scenes in 1 Kings 20, the description of the preparation is given much more space than is that of the decisive event.

The seven-day period during which the armies face each other before the second battle (v. 29) has no determinable significance when viewed in isolation.¹⁹ It is related succinctly, not dwelt on by the narrator to delay the progress of the narrative in order to increase its suspense. Presumably, then, it has some other purpose. Taken with the fall of the wall (v. 30) it can easily be understood as an allusion to the fall of Jericho,²⁰ stressing the miraculous nature of the victory.

The Negotiation

The description of the exchange of messages in the opening verses of 1 Kings 20 shows several syntactic features which are unusual, or have been interpreted in unusual ways. The discussion below is based on the assumption that, as in other languages, the choice of an uncommon feature shows that the common equivalent would not have been adequate. That is, uncommon usage carries a

particular meaning beyond the basic lexical and syntactic value of the words and the structure they form.

In 1 Kgs 20:3, Ben Hadad sends to Ahab a message in the form of two verbless clauses in which the extraposed subject is followed by the predicate and then by the pronoun resuming the subject: *הם לי הוא וגשיר ובניך הטובים לי הם* "Your silver and gold belongs to me; your wives and handsome sons belong to me." The structure is not common, but is well understood. It highlights both the items named (the subject) and "to me," the claim that Ben Hadad owns them (the predicate).²¹

Ben Hadad's second message begins (v. 5): *כי שלחתי אליך לאמר כספך וזהבך וגשיר ובניך לי תתן* "I sent to you saying 'Your silver and gold and wives and children to me you will give.'" This structure, with two constituents preceding the verb, is rare in prose, and so requires comment. It seems most likely that it highlights the two initial constituents which are, as in the clauses in verse 3, the items named, and "to me," the claim that Ben Hadad should receive them. If the verb were a significant innovation, one would expect, at least, that it begin the clause, if not that it be highlighted by the use of an infinitive absolute.²²

The first clause in verse 6 is introduced by *כי אם*. The two words probably represent a single conjunctive particle, but the use here is without exact parallel in biblical prose.²³ Long's view that *אם* is here an independent conditional particle is attractive for this reason, but it presents serious problems in other ways. Long regards the first clause in v. 6 as a threat. If this view is correct, v. 5 must convey a command to Ahab to deliver up his wives and children. The opening of the message, "Yesterday I sent to you saying....," does not suggest a command. The verb of the following clause, *תתן*, could convey a command (though not imperative in form) but, since it is not highlighted, it is unlikely that it does so.²⁴ It is easiest to take Ben Hadad's demand in verse 5 as a stylistic variation of that in verse 3; verbal syntax replaces verbless. Another variation appears in Ahab's report of the claim in verse 7.

Long's view also requires that *ולא מנעתי ממנו* in verse 7 be translated as a question referring to the future: "Should I not refuse him?" If this view is right, Ahab's question is crucial; the answer will determine Israel's future relationship with Aram. It is, then, surprising that the question should not be put formally, with an introductory interrogative particle. The Hebrew perfect form is quite often used where English would use a present or future tense, but this example does not fit the common categories of such usage.²⁵ If Long's interpretation is correct, then, the usage is abnormal, and comment on it should include an explanation of why such usage was chosen for the situation. The common use of the perfect form suggests that the verse is simply a report on the negotiation, ending "He sent to me for my wives, etc., and I did not withhold them from him."

Ahab's final rejection of Ben Hadad's demands is given in the form *והדבר הזה לא אוכל לעשות* "This thing I cannot do." "This thing" is highlighted by its position preceding both the verb and the infinitive of which it is object. This presumably shows that, while other actions, though distasteful, may be possible, "this thing" is not.²⁶ C. T. Begg has pointed out that the identification of "this thing" is the key to the problems posed by this interchange of messages, but, as his survey of the suggestions shows, its identity is not clear.²⁷

The demand made in verse 3 was not rejected by Ahab. It can, then, be accepted as the narrator's representation of something normal in the circumstances. If, as is argued here, this demand is repeated in variant form in verse 5, then the unacceptable demand must be presented in verse 6. It is reasonable to assume that the narrator intended this demand both as clearly abnormal in a situation of this sort, and as illustrating the character of Ben Hadad/Aram. Such illustration would naturally reinforce the lesson that Ahab's making peace with Aram after his victory was misguided. The requirements seem best fitted by the view characterized by Begg as "more widespread." Ahab's ready submission to the request for a specific tribute emboldens Ben Hadad to demand unconditional surrender. Ben Hadad is shown to be violent ("looking for trouble" v. 7) and rapacious.

Conclusion

It is easy, then, to understand 1 Kings 20 as the composition of an individual with a particular purpose. A narrative about Ahab is here used to demonstrate the power of God, and the value of obedience to him. The conclusion of Long (whose careful study of the intention of the narrator is limited to 1 Kgs 20:1-34) is consistent with this view. The "desire to express dramatically a particularizing vision of events" which Long sees (pp. 415-416) reflects the intention of rendering the lesson taught by the narrative readily applicable not only to the community Israel, but also to the individual reader.

The interpretation on which this conclusion is based is only superficially presented, but enough has been said to show that it is firmly based on linguistic features. As stated in the introduction, the primary purpose of the article is to demonstrate the need for more careful consideration of such features, particularly unusual usage. The understanding of such usage is, to a large extent, dependent on the understanding of the context of the usage, and so is not objective. Nevertheless, it can scarcely be argued that an interpretation which ignores unusual usage is preferable to one which attempts to understand it. The problem is similar to that encountered with lexical items such as *נער*, and should be met in the same way. The comprehensive study of grammatical features in their contexts, and of parallels in cognate languages, is (as with lexical items) the best insurance against undue subjectivity.

NOTES

1. The article originated as a paper presented to the Institute for Advanced Studies in the Humanities in the University of Edinburgh in January, 1987. I am most grateful for the advantages provided by a fellowship there.
2. The introduction by Robert E. Longacre to his book *Joseph* (Winona Lake, Ind., 1989) provides a suitable theoretical background to the view presented here. Note particularly his comments on "macrostructure" (the features which indicate the narrator's intention, pp. 17, 42, 139), and on the view that linguistic variation is motivated (p. xiii).
3. J. H. Tigay's discussion of "The Stylistic Criterion of Source Criticism in the Light of Ancient Near Eastern and Postbiblical Literature," in *Empirical Models for Biblical Criticism*, ed. J. H. Tigay, (Philadelphia, 1985), 149-173, illustrates the value of "stylistic" criteria, (on which, as he says on p. 150, most recognition of biblical sources is based), in tracing sources. However, it also illustrates the difficulty of distinguishing the extent to which a source has been used on this basis, when the source itself is not available to us in any form. The interpretation of such features of "style" can only be based on a view of the narrator's intention. Thus, for Würthwein, the contrast between the formulaic language of 1 Kgs 20:13-14, 28, and the lively style of the surrounding material indicates a difference in source. (Ernst Würthwein, *Die Bücher der Könige: 1. Kön. 17-2. Kön. 25.*, Das Alte Testament Deutsch 11,2 [Göttingen, 1984], 244). It could also be interpreted as representing the attempt of a single narrator to introduce a convincing prophetic character into his narrative.
4. See the survey in Martin Rehm, *Das erste Buch der Könige: ein Kommentar* (Würzburg, 1979), 195-197. He refers to the two sources as "einer profanen Geschichtsdarstellung" and "einer Prophetengeschichte" (p. 196). He views the latter as more extensive than do most.
5. This is in addition to the fact that it allows the narrator to depict contemporaneous events in the two camps, as pointed out by Burke O. Long, "Historical Narrative and the Fictionalizing Imagination," *Vetus Testamentum* 35(1985): 405-416 (henceforth Long), note 3.
6. אִלֵּי וַיִּבְרָא vv. 12, 13, 14, וַיִּבְרָא v. 13. A translator is at a crux in such cases. A target language is likely to require different translations of the root in some of these cases, if only in the interests of literary style, but such variation must diminish the impact of the Hebrew repetition.
7. Long (note 3) has already argued that the chapter is a unity with the possible exception of verses 35-43.
8. Thus subject-verb order is rare in the narrative sections (as opposed to quoted speech) of Jgs 4, 1 Sm 11, 22, 2 Sm 6, 24, 1 Kgs 13, 17, 2 Kgs 2, 7. It is moderately common in the "Succession Narrative," but its function is usually different from that of the examples described in 1 Kgs 20. A section of narrative may be initiated in a variety of ways, as described in Longacre, *Joseph*, 66-70.
9. It is generally accepted that Ahab was not originally the king of Israel of the historical sections, according to Würthwein, *Die Bücher der Könige*, 244. Opinions on the reign which is described vary; see G. H. Jones, *I and II Kings*, New Century Bible (Grand Rapids, Mich., 1984), 337, 339.
10. Long, 413. Detailed accounts of fighting are sometimes given, as in Jos 8:9-29, Jgs 9:34-54, 20:29-48.
11. Long's interpretation of the significance of the drinking (p. 415) is certainly possible, but does not seem to be required by the wording. His view that the narrator's intention is to emphasize the value of God's care for Israel is surely correct.
12. This chapter is preceded by Elijah's slaughter of the prophets of Baal in 1 Kgs 18, and by the foretelling (1 Kgs 19:17) of the activities of Jehu in 2 Kgs 9-10. Chapter 20 includes

language characteristic of the "Holy War" theme; cf. particularly חרם in v. 42. This required that Israel be cleared of pagan worship and sequestered from foreign contacts. There is a similar lack of explicit statement of what should be generally known in 1 Kgs 18. It is clear that pagan worship has caused the drought (1 Kgs 18:18 read in the light of Dt 11:16-17), and that the emphatic rejection of it represented by the slaughter of the priests of Baal brings the release from drought (1 Kgs 18:40-41). However, neither the slaughter nor the connection between drought and pagan worship is emphasized. The audience is expected to understand.

13. The usual understanding of תשקול in the common sense of "pay," gives the soldier of the prophet's narrative a choice between death or a fine as punishment. Ahab, whose conduct is symbolized by that of the soldier, is condemned to death with no option. The understanding as "receive (as a reward)" as in 2 Sm 18:12, avoids this discrepancy. Cf. Ralbag's comment on 1 Kgs 20:39.
14. It is pointed out by Longacre (*Joseph*, 42) that arguments of this sort are circular. The best result that can reasonably be expected from the interpretation of ancient materials is a self-consistent network of probabilities. It is doubtful if arguments can be made which are not, at base, circular.
15. See Hans-Peter Stähli, *Knabe-Jüngling-Knecht: Untersuchungen zum Begriff נער im Alten Testament* (Frankfurt am Main, 1978), 276.
16. In 2 Sm 2:14, the request יקומו נא הנערים וישחקו לפנינו leads to a combat between twelve men on either side. However, the use of the root שחק here suggests that the wording of the request is jocular: "Let the lads get up and amuse us." The use of נער might also be a mark of jocularity.
17. They carry equipment (Jgs 9:54, etc.), guide the blind prisoner Samson (Jgs 16:26), act as porters (1 Sm 26:22, 2 Kgs 5:23), messengers (2 Sm 1:5), lookouts (2 Sm 13:34), executioners (2 Sm 1:15, 4:12), or assassins (2 Sm 13:29, 18:15). Recent studies have tried to define the group designated by the term more exactly. Suggestions are: "an unmarried male who has not yet become the head of a household" – a type of person frequently employed in the army (L. E. Stager, "The Archaeology of the Family in Ancient Israel," *Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research* 260[1985]: 25-26); "a squire – most likely an apprentice who would someday become a full-fledged warrior himself" (A. F. Rainey, "Three Additional Texts" *apud* Yohanan Aharoni, *Arad Inscriptions* [Jerusalem, 1981], 123); and (referring to the use of the term on seals) "an established class of officials," whose exact function is not known, but who may be assumed, on the pattern of Ziba, the נער of Saul, to have been "custodians of property, administrators of estates, and the like," often in the service of private persons (Nahman Avigad, "The Contribution of Hebrew Seals to an Understanding of Israelite Religion and Society," in *Ancient Israelite Religion*, ed. P. D. Miller, P. D. Hanson, and S. D. McBride [Philadelphia, 1987], 205).
18. The usual term for them would be עבדים "slaves [of the king]." In 1 Kgs 12:8, ילד is opposed to נקן instead of the more usual נער – possibly because the latter term would be inappropriate for the companions of the young king.
19. Different views of the intention of the narrator will suggest different explanations, e.g., John Gray's suggestion that the armies may have waited for omens (*I and II Kings: a Commentary*, 2d rev. ed., Old Testament Library [London, 1970], 428). One would not expect the delay to be worth mentioning simply as a fact of history unless the reason for it were also worth mentioning.
20. Jos 6:13-15, 20, suggested by Joseph Robinson, *The First Book of Kings*, The Cambridge Bible Commentary (Cambridge, 1972), 231, followed by Rehm, *Das erste Buch der Könige*, 201. It is possible that the designation of Apheq as the site of the battle is a similar allusion to the site of Saul's final defeat (1 Sm 29:1) intended to increase the expectation of a disaster for Israel.

21. There are now several studies on the significance of word order in Hebrew. See Lars Lode, "Postverbal Word Order in Biblical Hebrew," *Semitics* 9(1984): 113-164; Walter Gross, *Die Pendens-konstruktion im biblischen Hebräisch*, ASAT, 27 (St. Ottilien, 1987); Geoffrey Khan, *Studies in Semitic Syntax* (Oxford, 1988). In *Joseph*, Longacre deals with the significance of word order in relation to the overall presentation of the narrative. On the structure of these verbless clauses, see Revell, "The Conditioning of Word Order in Verbless Clauses in Biblical Hebrew," *Journal of Semitic Studies* 34 (1989):9(#23).
22. Another example of the structure occurs in 1 Kgs 20:34 ואני בברית אשלחך. The highlighting of ואני supports the view that the speaker has changed, and that of בברית supports the view that the "treaty" is of particular significance in the context, as suggested in Long's note 8. (However, the presentation of a new speaker with no introductory verb of speaking is certainly unusual, and needs further comment if the text is not considered corrupt). Other examples of a verb preceded by two (or more) constituents occur in the Former Prophets in Jos 3:8, Jgs 2:15, 17:6 = 21:25, 1 Sm 3:18, 4:16, 6:9, 10:19, 20:20, 2 Sm 3:22, 5:2, 8:18, 15:34, 17:27-29, 20:4, 1 Kgs 6:7, 7:8, 10:29, 21:7, 2 Kgs 5:13 (as usually interpreted), 7:18, 14:6, 16:15.
23. וכן אשׁ gives positive emphasis to the word or clause it precedes. It commonly follows a negative clause, and restricts the application of the negative. See Bruce K. Waltke and Michael P. O'Connor, *An Introduction to Biblical Hebrew Syntax* (Winona Lake, Ind., 1990), #39.3.5d. Elsewhere, it may be used in an oath context (ibid. #40.2.2b), or in other situations affirming a fact (Ex 22:22, 1 Sm 21:6) or an intention (Jgs 15:7). The use in 1 Kgs 20 resembles this last.
24. The verb is unlikely to be a jussive, as a jussive form typically begins its clause. See Revell, "The System of the Verb in Standard Biblical Prose," *Hebrew Union College Annual* 60 (1989): 1-37, #14.5. In the examples of hortatory discourse discussed by Longacre (*Joseph*), indicative imperfects are used to amplify or explain commands (ex.1, p. 124, ex.2, p. 125). יעשה (Gn 41:34) may be an example of an indicative presenting a command, but a jussive form is expected (ex.5, p. 133. Cf. Revell, "System of the Verb," #22.1). In much of his interpretation of the passage, Long follows T. J. Meek, "1 Kings 20:1-10," *Journal of Biblical Literature* 78(1959): 73-75. Meek (p. 74) translates the opening words of v. 6 אשלחך as "For if I have to send..." but offers no support for the words "have to." Long (p. 407) does not use these words, but, as a result, his translation contains no threat unless verse 5 clearly contains a command compliance with which would make the sending unnecessary.
25. Perfect forms are regularly used for states or conditions which originated in the past, but continue in the present. וקנתי "I am old" (I have become old) in 1 Sm 12:2, which Long (n. 6) offers in support of his views, belongs in this category; מנעתי with the suggested meaning "shall I withhold?" would not. Perfect forms are also often used for actions originating in a decision made in the past, even when they have not taken place, as מכרה (Ruth 4:3) "Naomi is selling/will sell" (she has decided to sell). Here Ahab is asking for advice on which to base a decision. Other uses of the perfect form in the Former Prophets, including apparent anomalies, are described in Revell, "System of the Verb," #3-7. The description of Waltke and O'Connor, which has a wider basis and a different viewpoint, includes categories to which Long's interpretation might be assigned (*Syntax* #30.5.1e).
26. Compare ערות הארץ באתם לראות (Gn 42:12) specifically highlighting the initial noun "The nakedness of the land [is what] you have come to see!" with באתם לראות את ערות הארץ (Gn 42:9) where the whole infinitive phrase is highlighted "To see the nakedness...[is the purpose for which] you have come!." Where the modifier alone is highlighted (the first example), the infinitive takes its standard position (after the verb), as does a participle (after the subject) in a verbless clause. See Revell, "Conditioning of Word Order," #18.

27. "This Thing I Cannot Do," *Scandinavian Journal of the Old Testament* 2(1989): 23-27. Begg's own view, that Ahab is reacting to implied questioning of his royal honor (p. 26), is certainly possible, but, for me, not persuasive.

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